

ONLY MUSIC PLEASE: 2.1 SPEAKERS

The most basic speaker sets are the 2.1 category. However, it's a mistake to think of them as speakers that have less to offer. It's more about usage patterns, and if you're more into listening to MP3s and rarely play any games or watch DVD movies on your PC, it's kind of pointless to look for anything more than a good 2.1 set. This is because most of the sound sources you will be listening to have just two channels—left and right. Only DVD movies and newer games have more channels (5.1 or 7.1), whereas all your music collection and any VCDs you might have on your PC are just stereo.

If you decide that you don't need anything more than a 2.1 speaker system, the next thing is to decide on a budget. 2.1 speaker sets range from the lowest-priced sets to some of the most expensive audiophile-grade systems. Most PC users buy the inexpensive, entry-level 2.1 sets, which consist of two satellites and a subwoofer. The subwoofer plays back the lower frequency sounds extracted from the stereo input.

Making it to this category were 16 sets—from Altec Lansing, Artis, Creative, Intex, Logitech, Tech-Com, XFree, and Zebronics.

Features Power

We attempted to take a look at many aspects of the speakers, and power rating is one of the most important. A speaker set with a higher power rating will produce sound of higher amplitude, since they amplify the sound to a larger degree. All the power ratings we'll mention in this review are in RMS, unless mentioned otherwise. In the case of the 2.1 speaker sets, the Altec Lansing FX4021 boasted of an individual satellite power rating of 11 W, while the subwoofer pumped out 46 W. The Zebronics ZEB-SW8000 was next with satellites rated at 10 W each and the subwoofer rated at 30 W. Xfree's XE222 were the lowest-powered of them all, with a 2.5 W satellite and a 4 W subwoofer.

Driver Size

The size of the driver (speaker diaphragm) is one of the determining factors in the ability of the speaker to produce sound (see box *Size Does Matter*). Because most of the 2.1 speaker systems were targeted at the budget segment, we did not expect to find anything spectacular in this regard. However, the Altec Lansing ATP3 boasted of a 6.5-inch woofer, while the FX4021 had two 5.25-inch drivers in isobaric configuration (facing each other) to provide double the amount of bass. It was natural for us to expect some rocking bass from these speaker sets. The rest of the speaker sets had woofer sizes ranging from 4 to 5.25 inches.

As far as the satellites were concerned, the Altec Lansing ATP3 had an unusual design, with two 28 mm drivers and a 3-inch down-firing mid-bass. The FX4021 from the same brand had satellites with 40 mm and 18 mm drivers to deal with a higher range of frequencies. The Logitech X-230 also sported dual 2-inch drivers to produce a uniform sound field and to eliminate uneven response.

Other Features

Clamp-type connectors are usually found only in higher-end speaker systems because of the better conductivity and contact, and we were surprised to find them in the Altec Lansing 121i and the Artis S444 and S800. The rest of the speaker sets had the more common RCA contacts, while the Creative SBS-370 was the only one with mono contacts, which are prone to problems.

Bass as well as treble controls along with volume controls were there on most of the sets except for the Artis, Creative, Logitech and Xfree.

Accessories

As accessories go, Creative bundled large, heavy power adapters. While Creative had some nice-looking detachable stands, the Altec Lansing FX4021 came with good-looking metal stands, which added to their aesthetic appeal. Speaking of aesthetics, the Logitech X-230 was the most dashing-looking 2.1 set, with a jet-black sub-

Illustration Chaitanya Surpur
Photograph Jiten Gandhi, Amrut Patki
Model Shivam

